

The Vigor of a Disregarded Ally in Sponsorship: Brand Image Transfer Effects Arising from a Cosponsor

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ABSTRACT

Typically, brands vie for image transfer from an event or other property when entering a sponsorship engagement. Yet, this practice leaves a valuable part of a sponsorship alliance unexploited. This study addresses a new opportunity for brand collaboration that may arise from the vigor of a disregarded ally. Specifically, the authors infer from congruity theory and associative learning theory to propose a research model that advocates the idea of a sponsor to also gain from brand attitude and personality traits innately tied to a cosponsor paired with the same event. Structural equation and, respectively, path model testing provide evidence for direct transfer of attitudes as well as for carryover of personality traits between two sponsor brands. These transfer effects turn out to be moderated by perceived fit between the sponsor brands' images and by familiarity with the target sponsor brand. Brand managers may want to bring these findings to bear in sponsorship policy design and execution by purposefully choosing with whom they share a perimeter billboard or any other sponsorship signage. Such a deliberate approach stands in contrast to current sponsorship practice where agents tend to disregard linked cosponsors and, instead, fortuitously yield up to their fate. © 2015 Wiley Periodicals, Inc.

It has long been acknowledged that sponsorship offers unique opportunities for positioning a brand in the marketplace and for deploying brand strategy (Cliffe & Motion, 2005). Beyond contributing to brand awareness, enhancement of thoughts, beliefs, and feelings for a sponsor brand through transfer of brand image from a sponsorship property has traditionally been a predominant objective of sponsorship (Cornwell, Roy, & Steinard, 2001; Walliser, 2003). Indeed, corresponding to the idea of brand image transfer, Keller (1993) noted that secondary brand associations may arise from inferences consumers make from inherently linking one branded entity to another branded entity, such as an event or a celebrity spokesperson, and a plethora of empirical studies in the field confirmed that notion. From a practice-oriented perspective, the case of GoPro, a manufacturer of high-definition personal cameras predominantly used in extreme action video photography, joining forces with the X Games sports event series (GoPro, 2013) may serve as an example for a sponsor that successfully cultivates its brand image by linking to a branded sponsorship property. Determinants, such as event type “(extreme sports)”, specific event characteristics (e.g., exclusive line-up of the world's top athletes, juvenile audience), or perceived status of the event (Gwinner, 1997; Speed & Thompson, 2000), may contribute to the pronounced event image that GoPro's management apparently val-

ues highly. Since sponsorship properties such as sports events can be considered brands in their own right (Lee & Cho, 2009) possessing distinct personality characteristics (Lee & Cho, 2012; Meenaghan, 1983, 2001b), sponsor brands justifiably assume to benefit from these customer perceptions by inference. Along these lines GoPro will engage in further strengthening key brand personality traits, such as excitement, ruggedness, or competence by means of affiliation to the X Games.

Also, as sponsorship is generally conceived a means of communication less coercive and obtrusive than, for example, advertising (Meenaghan, 2001a), a high level of credibility for the message is attributed to it and, hence, the instrument is deemed suitable for conveying brand images in an unbiased rather than distorted fashion. It might be ascribed to such facilities that sponsorship has been exalted by practitioners above other means of marketing, leading to annual growth rates that surpassed those of traditional media as well as promotional activity on a global scale, most notably in the United States (IEG, 2014). However, sponsorship has come under pressure by the enticement that accrues from digital forms of marketing, especially social media and mobile. In reference to these pressures and in an attempt to nudge the sponsorship medium, the current study addresses a new opportunity for brand strategy design and execution that may reside within a sponsorship alliance. Specifically, the possibility of a

sponsor brand to not only benefitting from the exploitation of a sponsorship property's image, but also gaining from the attitudes and associations innately tied to a linked cosponsor will be explored. Such an integrative perspective on image transfer in sponsorship with a focus on the contingent effect of a cosponsor on a target sponsor may shed light on the vigor of an ally that has been disregarded so far.

The vast majority of research on brand image transfer in sponsorship has focused on the investigation of solo sponsorships (e.g., Dean, 2002; Grohs & Reisinger, 2005; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Lardinoit & Quester, 2001; Rifon, Choi, Trimble, & Li, 2004; Speed & Thompson, 2000; Zdravkovic & Till, 2012). This is in marked contrast to sponsorship practice where simultaneous presentation of multiple sponsors is commonplace (Carrillat, Harris, & Lafferty, 2010). With the exception of event-marketing activities that are usually internally initiated by a firm and center on promoting a single brand by definition, it is quite common today to find a roster of sponsors presented on a single sponsorship property (Ruth & Simonin, 2006). Moreover, owing to sponsorship hierarchies that deliberately aim at creating categories of equally ranked sponsors (e.g., national supporters) or due to unintentional equalization of formally unequal sponsors through forms of presentation that render perceptions of these sponsors' hierarchy levels undistinguishable (e.g., side-by-side signage), such a roster may be perceived by the audience as a cluster of brands cooperating on eye level in some way. Take the Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA) as an illustrative example. Not only is the organization sponsored by six major corporate brands each of which maintains the status of a FIFA Partner, but also does none of these sponsors occupy a salient position with regard to brand presentation. There is no such thing as a paramount main sponsor. That is, six partner brands are presented abreast on an equal sponsorship-hierarchy level. Surprisingly, direct transfer of attitudes and associations between brands concurrently sponsoring the same property has received scant research attention as yet. So far, only two studies have addressed this gap in sponsorship literature (see Carrillat et al., 2010; Sattler, Schnittka, & Völckner, 2012). However, the study at hand is the first to investigate the issue comprehensively (i.e., considering both the attitude-based and the personality-based perspective on brand image) and in a way as to discriminate potential prior associations between two sponsors from a unique experimental effect (Gross, 2014). Contrasting this specific gap in sponsorship literature, a general lack of scientific evidence on the question of how one brand imbues another brand when these are presented alongside each other is not to be lamented. A solid body of theoretical and empirical knowledge concerning image transfer in a multiple-brand context has been gathered in other fields of marketing research, such as the creation of brand alliances (e.g., Park, Jun, & Shocker, 1996; Rao & Ruekert, 1994; Rao, Qu, & Ruekert, 1999; Simonin & Ruth, 1998; Washburn,

Till, & Priluck, 2004), cobranding (e.g., Shocker, 1995; Walchli, 2007; Washburn, Till, & Priluck, 2000), advertising alliance building (e.g., Samu, Krishnan, & Smith, 1999), or dual branding (e.g., Levin, 2002; Levin & Levin, 2000). Cornwell, Weeks, and Roy (2005), hence, call for informing sponsorship inquiry by insights from these veins of research and note that from a practitioner's standpoint "companies undertaking nonexclusive sponsorships may also need to consider which other brands will be present at the event, since the presence of controversial products could promote negative attitudes . . . toward related sponsors." (p. 36) Likewise, Ruth and Simonin (2003) underscore the importance of investigating image transfer taking place between concurrent sponsors by framing an important question that remained unexamined so far as "how the presence of multiple sponsors ultimately affects each participating brand" (p. 27). The present study set out to address this gap in sponsorship literature and aims at embracing sponsorship reality by investigating the question of how a preexisting image associated with one sponsor brand may influence evaluations of another brand sponsoring the same property. This work also extends on the existing literature by conceptualizing the brand image construct from a personality-based perspective (Aaker, 1997; Geuens, Weijters, & De Wulf, 2009) in addition to the purely attitude-based perspective adhered to by many authors. In contrast to the attitude-based perspective, which provides a general evaluation of a brand (e.g., bad/good), the personality-based assessment takes into account a roster of discrete associations (e.g., down to earth; dynamic) each of which is characteristic of a brand to a greater or lesser degree. Consequently, the prevailing attitude-related approach is contended here to fall short of practical relevance since brand managers are mainly concerned with nurturing a distinct brand personality profile rather than establishing a vague brand attitude. In order to limit the experimental complexities, the study is confined to the investigation of image transfer effects between sponsors that are on an equal sponsorship hierarchy level.

This article is structured as follows. First, the conceptual background on the notion of a sponsorship alliance is provided. Second, this study's underlying apprehension of the capacity of congruity theory as well as of associative learning theory in explaining the mental process of image transfer will be outlined. Third, a research model will be developed comprising all relevant image transfer relations that may emerge between a single sponsorship property and two concurrent sponsor brands. Such a comprehensive approach allows for investigating the image relation of central interest, namely the one between the two sponsor brands, while still accounting for image effects that might be attributable to the sponsorship property. Brand image fit and brand familiarity as two variables suggested to interact with the process of image transfer will be incorporated into the research model as moderator variables. Fourth, research design and methodological approach to hypotheses testing are outlined briefly. Fifth, the re-

sults of an experiment conducted in the Swiss sponsorship market will be presented and discussed, followed by, sixth, the presentation of a general conclusion focusing on practical implications. Finally, instigation of further research endeavors is aspired through charting two potential paths for future investigation deemed beneficial in augmenting this research's insights.

SPONSORSHIP ALLIANCE

Interest in brand alliances as a means to brand building has experienced explosive growth in recent years (Gammoh & Voss, 2011). Prominent examples can be found across an individual's everyday consumption experience as marketers engage in strategies such as cobranding (e.g., the Nike+iPod sports combo), ingredient branding (e.g., Adidas sneakers designed by Yohji Yamamoto), or advertising alliances (e.g., Google naming its most recent Android-based operating system after Nestlé's KitKat brand). In fact, pairing of brands has proliferated in a way as to incite Kapferer (2012) to declare that "the modern world is a world of alliances and partnerships between groups, companies, brands and so on" (p. 146). Rao et al. (1999) provided a widely accepted, though considerably broad, definition of a brand alliance as all circumstances in which "two or more brand names are presented jointly to the consumer" (p. 259).

This understanding of a brand alliance corresponds to the situation found in sponsorship where multiple sponsor brands associate with a property brand (e.g., an event, a team, a celebrity) and, hence, an assemblage of brand names is collectively presented to the consumer. Building on that, the introduction of what is referred to as a sponsorship alliance is suggested at this place. The concept emphasizes the collaborative aspiration of a sponsorship property brand and two or more sponsor brands. By explicitly addressing potential synergies between the sponsor brands, it extends on the notion of cosponsorship that connotes a fortuitous combination of these constituents. Given that in cosponsorships the pairing of the property with an individual sponsor usually results from some deliberate consideration on the part of these two parties, it is the volitional nature (as opposed to the fortuitous one) of the coalition between the sponsor brands that sets the idea of the sponsorship alliance apart the concept of a cosponsorship. Concerning the existence of one single commonly marked product as it might be expected for any sort of brand alliance but which is obviously lacking in the case of a sponsorship alliance, reference to Rao et al.'s (1999) assertion that "alliances range from multiple brands that are physically integrated in a product . . . to *multiple brands that simply are featured in joint promotions* [emphasis added]" (p. 259) legitimizes an intangible entity like an event to be apprehended as the facilitator of the collaborative aspiration purported here.

THEORETICAL PERSPECTIVES ON BRAND IMAGE TRANSFER IN A SPONSORSHIP ALLIANCE

Corresponding to conceptualizing the image construct from both an attitude- and a personality-based perspective, congruity and associative learning theory, respectively, are employed as two theoretical frameworks from which to investigate brand image transfer in a sponsorship alliance. While the principles of congruity explain attitude transfer between brands building on the idea that individuals strive for cognitive harmony upon perceiving an assertion made by a message-source on a concept and that these individuals will reconcile existing attitudes if required, associative learning provides an understanding of how parts of a brand's associative network might become integrated into the cognitive map of a brand with which it cooccurs.

Congruity Theory

Congruity theory has been proposed by Osgood and Tannenbaum (1955) and is one of three major theories originating in social psychology that embrace the principle of cognitive consistency. The two others are balance theory developed by Heider (1958) and the theory of cognitive dissonance advocated by Festinger (1957). All of these theories hold that individuals seek to maintain consistency or internal harmony among their attitudes, values, opinions, or behaviors (Levin, Davis, & Levin, 1996). Specifically, the idea of cognitive consistency conjectures that when an individual mentally holds two or more objects or concepts that are relevant to each other in some way but inconsistent with one another, a state of imbalance or discomfort is created. Such inner arousal will motivate the individual to alter evaluations on some or all of the entities in an attempt to attenuate the felt discrepancy. The theories building on the tenet of cognitive consistency occupy a prominent role in informing sponsorship research (see, e.g., Dalakas & Levin, 2005; Dean, 2002; Russell & Stern, 2006).

In congruity theory, which is specifically oriented toward communication and persuasion, the paradigm of (in-)congruence relates to the (dis-)harmony perceived by a person who is confronted with an assertion on an object or a concept about which he or she feels in a certain way, made by a message-source toward which he or she also has an attitude, with the attitudinal relationship between the message-source and the object/concept (not) corresponding to the evaluative connotation of the assertion (Zajonc, 1960). In other words, if the assertion made by a message-source (e.g., Barack Obama) on a concept (e.g., health-care reform) is of positive valence, the observing person will reconsider preexisting attitudes toward one or both of the source and the concept (e.g., Obama is more/less admirable than I thought and/or health care is worse/better than I thought) if these evaluative entities are currently not hold in similar esteem. Likewise,

a mental “pressure toward congruity” (Osgood & Tannenbaum, 1955, p. 46) will emerge if the assertion is of negative valence but the corresponding attitudes do currently match. By contrast, these attitude-altering forces are mute in the case of harmony and balance felt between personal attitudes and assertion.

The unique characteristics determining congruity theory’s suitability in the context of image transfer in sponsorship (as opposed to, e.g., balance theory) are that in congruity theory attitudes are proposed to adapt in a gradual manner (as opposed to an all-or-none mode) and that the presence of incongruity can prompt a change in attitude toward both the message-source and the evaluated object/concept simultaneously (as opposed to an either-or mode). With regard to the applicability of congruity theory’s propositions to sponsorship research, Meenaghan (2001b) affirms that “although the principle of congruence is most often articulated in terms of source and message (Osgood & Tannenbaum, 1955), it was felt that a sufficient degree of parallel application existed in the case of commercial sponsorship to merit investigation” (p. 104). This credo is adopted here.

Inference from the principles of congruity theory suggests that a consumer engages in establishing attitudinal accord among brands perceived as linked by means of a sponsorship alliance. If attitudes toward these brands do currently not match, pressure toward congruity will trigger assimilation of brand attitudes that is tantamount to a reciprocal conveyance of beliefs or feelings. In other words, if two or more brands converge with regard to the inner pictures or mental concepts held by a person, these brands are said to be subject to attitude transfer (Carrillat et al., 2010; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999). It is suggested here that the link between sponsor brands constitutes an “implicit assertion” (Osgood & Tannenbaum, 1955, p. 44) of a brand that may be understood as the message-source made on another brand that may be looked upon as the concept that is being gauged. Relevant to this study is the implication that congruity theory contends attitude transfer to take place in either direction between each of the possible brand pairs pertaining to a sponsorship alliance. Such reasoning is plausible if every dyad of paired brands is regarded as representing one of congruity theory’s message-source/concept pairs with the cognitive arduousness of processing potentially discrepant elements resulting in assimilation and, thus, reciprocal transfer of attitudes. As the three possible dyads of a three brands sponsorship alliance (which is the most elementary sponsorship alliance possible comprising a single sponsorship property brand and two sponsor brands) “overlap” at one of the participating brands each, it stands to reason that attitudinal interference captures all of the three brands at once.

Associative Learning Theory

Work of cognitive psychologists (e.g., Anderson & Bower, 1973; Collins & Loftus, 1975; Wyer & Srull,

1986) has provided the impetus for a view on brand image that relies on brand names furnished in some way with a variety of associations or personality traits represented in consumer memory (John, Loken, Kim, & Monga, 2006). Associative learning theory gives a rationale for how the personality of one branded element may imbue the brand personality of a paired element with which it is frequently experienced by an individual. Albeit an intuitively reasonable approach, associative learning and the network model of human memory have provided the theoretical foundation of only a limited number of studies on image transfer and recall in sponsorship yet (see, e.g., Carrillat, Lafferty, & Harris, 2005; Chien, Cornwell, & Pappu, 2011; Henseler, Wilson, & de Vreede, 2009; Humphreys et al., 2010; Till, 1998). Inference from classical conditioning (Pavlov, 1927) will help in outlining the principles of associative learning as required for explaining brand image transfer.

The essential idea of classical conditioning is that a stimulus (conditioned stimulus) can become linked to an overt outcome such as a physiological reflex (unconditioned response), which has been, at first, the exclusive reaction to another stimulus (unconditioned stimulus). If the two stimuli are repeatedly presented together, the conditioned stimulus develops predictive qualities for the unconditioned stimulus and may come to elicit the response (conditioned response) when presented alone (McSweeney & Bierley, 1984). Associative learning builds on a comparable psychological mechanism yet substitutes an internal linkup between a stimulus and a nonovert, mental response for the external linkup to an overt reaction that is typically postulated in classical conditioning theory. Thus, learning under the auspices of classical conditioning as well as associative learning occurs if the conditioned stimulus reliably and predictably signals the occurrence of the unconditioned stimulus (Smith & Kosslyn, 2006).

In terms of image transfer between brands, this means that if brand A becomes predictive of brand B with which it is repeatedly paired, information traits exclusively linked to the associative network of brand B at first may become integrated into the associative network of brand A. This basic principle has been simplified in the sense of Hebbian learning (Hebb, 1949) as “what fires together, wires together” (Shatz, 1992; van Osselaer & Janiszewski, 2001, p. 205). That is, all elements being simultaneously retrieved from memory through the process of spreading activation (Anderson, 1983; Collins & Loftus, 1975) are cross-referenced by establishing simple associations that are strengthened each time these elements appear together. Akin to classical conditioning, this mechanism is reliant on close proximity of cues in space and time (Rescorla, 1988; Rydell & Jones, 2009; Schermer, 2006).

Applying the principles of associative learning to the context of a sponsorship alliance means that distinct parts of the individual cognitive networks pertaining to each of the constituent brands are activated

simultaneously upon encounter of the alliance. As the three information parcels “light up” in mind concurrently, their joint cognitive elaboration results in what has been coined an internal linkup between a stimulus and a nonovert, mental response above. That is, the cognitive representations of the three brands are cross-referenced and mutually weave parts of their associative networks. The necessary condition of spatio-temporal contiguity is naturally fulfilled in a sponsorship alliance as the sponsorship property brand and the sponsor brands are unmistakably presented as spatial and temporal neighbors through side-by-side signage. As such, associative learning provides for an explication of the transfer of brand associations or brand personality traits in either direction between each of the possible brand pairs pertaining to a sponsorship alliance.

RESEARCH MODEL

Brand Image Transfer from Cosponsor to Focal Sponsor

Image transfer between two brands concurrently sponsoring the same property has received scant research attention yet. Carrillat et al. (2010) addressed this gap in sponsorship literature by investigating how brands become associated with each other in consumers’ minds when they sponsor the same event concurrently. They found that the images of two familiar brands sponsoring the same event can be transferred between each other under the condition of having similar concepts. Yet, as set forth by the authors themselves, study design and measurement approach to image transfer (relying on between-sponsor image congruence) did not preclude the alleged transfer between sponsoring brands to stem from an illusionary rather than factual assimilation of brand images in the concurrent sponsorship condition compared to the solo sponsorship condition (Carrillat et al., 2010, Study 1). Namely, such an illusion may arise due to the two brands’ individual affiliation with the event resulting in an artificially decreased between-sponsor image congruence in the solo sponsorship condition compared to an absence of sponsorship, with the concurrent sponsorship condition bringing the congruence back to its original level. Increased congruence in the concurrent over the solo sponsorship condition is now erroneously taken for image transfer, while congruence levels in the concurrent sponsorship condition may, in fact, have remained unchanged compared to the true baseline which is an absence of sponsorship (i.e., the two sponsors preexposure congruence). As a remedy to that issue, a follow-up study (Carrillat et al., 2010, Study 2) includes a “no sponsorship” condition and, additionally, brand image transfer was chosen to be operationalized through absolute difference values between the brands’ average ratings on distinct personality attributes (compared to the measurement relying on between-sponsor image congruence as adopted in Study 1). However, the

authors’ particular usage of personality attributes introduces yet another flaw with regard to the ambition of assessing image transfer bona fide. Namely, the scope of investigation on between-sponsor image transfer is limited to the scrutiny of only two attributes (sincere and exciting). The study of effects on two singular attributes may serve an exemplary case concerning the fundamental workings of brand image transfer. But with a view to practical relevance, investigation of a more complete roster of personality traits is indicated.

Paying tribute to such piecemeal empirical evidence altogether, the current study mainly builds on congruity theory and associative learning theory to theoretically substantiate a more integral research hypothesis as follows (see full research model in Figure 1):

H1_{a/b}:¹ Preexposure attitude/associations attributed to a cosponsor is/are positively related to postexposure attitude/associations attributed to the focal sponsor.

Here, the notations of “cosponsor” and “focal sponsor” are used to semantically differentiate the sponsor brand that serves as a source of image transfer in the research model (the cosponsor) from the target sponsor brand to which image is presumably transferred (the focal sponsor). Stated differently, in order to outline a research model that addresses the question of whether or not one sponsor’s image may imbue another sponsor’s image when paired in a sponsorship alliance, “brand image of cosponsor” was chosen to be the label designating the one predictor variable that stands at the center of attention in the model suggested here, while “brand image of focal sponsor” is the term that has been selected to name the outcome variable of the model.

It is crucial to the concept of this study to expound that a cosponsor might not only deploy its image effect onto the focal sponsor through consumers’ direct inference. Specifically, it is conceivable that a cosponsor unfolds a fraction of its total image transference effect through a bypass route mediated by the image of the sponsorship property. Beyond being theoretically underpinned by congruity theory and associative learning theory, the first leg of this mediated route (i.e., transfer of brand image from cosponsor to sponsorship property) receives empirical support too—albeit from a very limited number of studies. Specifically, four studies give rise to the assumption that a sponsor’s image can rub off onto the image of the property. Ruth and Simonin (2003) show that the attitudes toward two sponsor brands as held by consumers account for a significant proportion of variance in consumers’ resulting attitude toward an advertised event. In a subsequent study, Ruth and Simonin (2006) build on attribution theory

¹ Research hypotheses are divided into a part pertaining to attitude transfer (subscript “a”) and a part concerning the rub-off of single brand associations (subscript “b”). Furthermore, the temporal prepositions “pre” and “post” are used to indicate brand images as existing before and after experimental intervention, respectively.

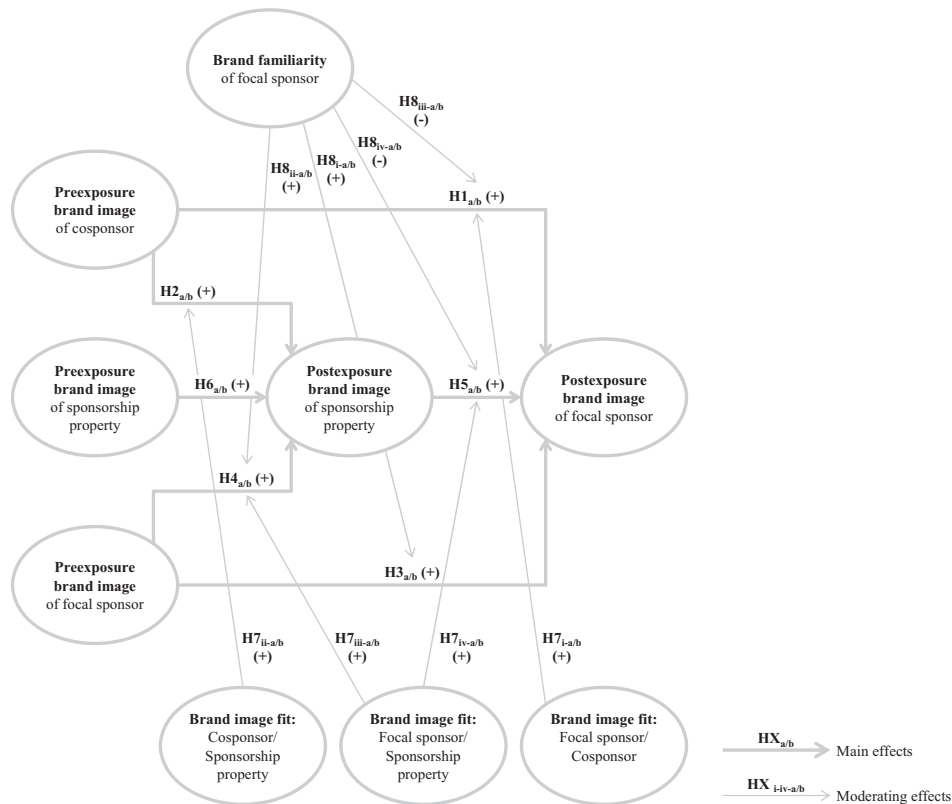


Figure 1. Research model on image transfer in a sponsorship alliance.

to find that consumers infer from sponsor motives (i.e., goodwill vs. sales oriented) to develop perceptions about an event. With an emphasis on the carryover of single brand associations rather than on the transference of attitudes Henseler et al. (2009) find that particular traits attributed to a sponsee can be influenced by the accordant traits attributed to a linked sponsor with the strength of the transfer being idiosyncratic for each of the traits. In the context of sports sponsorship, Burmann, Schade, and Kanitz (2013) conclude from their data that team brands and sports league brands may benefit from what they call reverse effects, that is, a positive brand image effect from sponsor brand to the team/sports league.

These empirical investigations support theoretical rationale regarding a sponsor brand image rubbing off onto the sponsorship property's image upon association of these objects by means of joint presentation through a sponsorship alliance. Hence, the following hypothesis is introduced:

H2_{a/b}: Preexposure attitude/associations attributed to a cosponsor is/are positively related to postexposure attitude/associations attributed to the sponsorship property.

Note that a rationale substantiating the second leg of the mediated route (i.e., brand image transfer from property to focal sponsor) will be provided in hypothesis H5.

Stability and Strength of Focal Sponsor Brand Image

The cognitive structures that represent brand images in consumers' minds build on substantial learning processes and result in an enduring and stable state of knowledge (Fiske & Pavelchak, 1986; Lord, Ross, & Lepper, 1979). Such relative permanence and cognitive rigidity of the image construct has also been highlighted and supported in sponsorship research. Sponsor brand images have been found slow to change due to their persistency that originates in a high level of brand coherence accrued over time (Grohs, Wagner, & Vsetecka, 2004). From his study on the effects of associating a corporation with a charitable event through sponsorship, Dean (2002) concludes that "corporate image will be slow to change through sponsorship, because the effects of any single sponsorship are muted by the lingering effects of the past corporate image" (p. 86). Thus, in order to examine modifications of the focal sponsor brand by virtue of image transfer in a sponsorship alliance, it is important to control for the focal sponsor's preexposure brand image:

H3_{a/b}: Preexposure attitude/associations attributed to the focal sponsor is/are positively related to the postexposure counterpart/-s.

As outlined before (see H2), a sponsor brand of considerable strength is presumed to pervade the brand

image of the sponsorship property. The following hypothesis reflects this anticipation in proposing the focal sponsor brand image to transfer to the event brand image:

- H4_{a/b}:** Preexposure attitude/associations attributed to the focal sponsor is/are positively related to postexposure attitude/associations attributed to the sponsorship property.

Brand Image Transfer from Sponsorship Property to Focal Sponsor

The exploitable commercial potential associated with a sponsorship property has been put forth as the key benefit for a sponsor brand in many definitions of the instrument (see, e.g., Ukman, 2004). In large parts, this potential arises from closely linking the sponsor brand to a property that is held in high regard among the sponsor's target group and, subsequently, the favorable image of that property rubbing off to the sponsor in the targeted subjects' minds. In fact, a plethora of scientific evidence has been gathered on this issue over the past two decades with the unambiguous insight of brand meaning or personality traits to carry over to a sponsor brand from a single property (Dalakas & Levin, 2005; Grohs et al., 2004; Stipp & Schiavone, 1996) or a portfolio of properties (Chien et al., 2011). In order for the research model to comply with the affirmation of a mediating role of the sponsorship property brand, the construct of postexposure property image is anticipated to exert influence onto the focal sponsor brand (this trajectory represents the second leg of the mediated route from cosponsor to sponsorship property and, ultimately, to focal sponsor as proposed before). Hence, given the affirmative and robust results on property-to-sponsor image transfer found in extant literature, the following hypothesis is posited:

- H5_{a/b}:** Postexposure attitude/associations attributed to the sponsorship property is/are positively related to postexposure attitude/associations attributed to the focal sponsor.

In the context of arguing for the need of controlling for the focal sponsor's preexposure brand image (see H3) the notion of relative permanence and cognitive rigidity of a brand image has been brought up before. On the same lines, brand image of the sponsorship property can be assumed to be of considerable stability over time too. Thus, the effect of the preexposure brand image of the sponsorship property must be covaried out for properly modeling the multifaceted effects onto the postexposure brand image of the sponsorship property. This leads to the following hypothesis:

- H6_{a/b}:** Preexposure attitude/associations attributed to the sponsorship property is/are positively related to the postexposure counterpart/s.

Moderating Effects on Image Transfer

With regard to brand managers' practical need to be able to intensify/mute the conveyance of wanted/unwanted beliefs or feelings onto their own brands, two variables proposed to moderate some of the hypothesized transfers are taken into account.

First, congruence or fit of the images of two brands as perceived by the audience is asserted to enhance image transfer between these brands. Early studies in the field of advertising applied schema theory to propose and test a matchup hypothesis in models of celebrity endorsement. For example, Misra and Beatty (1990) contended that information on a celebrity endorsing a brand will be more readily processed if a good matchup exists between the mental schemata of the celebrity and the brand. In contrast, new information about the brand radiating from the celebrity will be prevented from being processed by means of a mental filter if the schemata do not match well. Likewise, studies in sponsorship research are in support of a moderating effect of the fit construct (Carrillat et al., 2010; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999). It is inferred from these insights to posit that image transfer between any two brands of a sponsorship alliance is enhanced (inhibited), when these brands are perceived as high (low) in brand image fit:²

- H7_{i-a/b} through H7_{iv-a/b}:**
- i preexposure attitude/associations attributed to a cosponsor,
 - ii preexposure attitude/associations attributed to a cosponsor,
 - iii preexposure attitude/associations attributed to the focal sponsor,
 - iv postexposure attitude/associations attributed to the sponsorship property,
- and postexposure attitude/associations attributed to
- i the focal sponsor (as proposed in H1)
 - ii the sponsorship property (as proposed in H2)
 - iii the sponsorship property (as proposed in H4)
 - iv the focal sponsor (as proposed in H5)
- is enhanced (inhibited) when these brands are perceived as high (low) in brand image fit.

Second, a moderating effect of the focal sponsor's brand familiarity is proposed. By virtue of differences

² Beyond the moderating effects of brand image fit the full/original research model also accounts for brand image fit to exert direct effects on the endogenous variables. Yet, due to space restrictions, direct effects are omitted from further investigation here (refer to the contact author for additional information).

in perceived familiarity for the focal sponsor, the moderating effect is suggested to emanate (1) from a differential strength of the focal sponsor to *rub off onto a paired brand* (H8_{i-a/b} and H8_{ii-a/b}) and (2) from a variance as to the degree of susceptibility of the focal sponsor to *impingement from a paired brand* (H8_{iii-a/b} and H8_{iv-a/b}). Brands high in familiarity are said to be represented by cognitive structures with a large number of easily accessible associations, while brands low in familiarity possess only an insignificant number of shallow associations (Fazio, 1986; Kent & Allen, 1994). As the accessibility of attitudes or associations is positively related to these cognitions' strength of effect onto the perceptions of a related consumer object (Prislin, 1996), a brand may exert a stronger image effect over a paired brand if it possesses a more internalized associative network compared to when the brand is represented by less established cognitions. The differential strength of a brand to imbue a paired brand arising from variance in familiarity among consumers builds on these grounds:

- H8_{i-a/b} and H8_{ii-a/b}:** For higher (lower) levels of focal sponsor brand familiarity, the positive relationship between preexposure attitude/associations attributed to the focal sponsor and postexposure attitude/associations attributed to
- i that focal sponsor (as proposed in H3),
 - ii the sponsorship property (as proposed in H4)
- is enhanced (reduced).

In contrast, it has been suggested that image conveyance onto low-familiarity brands will be relatively strong because of their lack of an extensive network of prior associations (Bettman & Sujan, 1987; Fazio, 1989), while high-familiarity brands are more resistant to change due to the richness of attached beliefs. Also, studies on classical conditioning in consumer research suggest that subject's preexposure to an advertising stimulus and, hence, familiarity with that stimulus inhibits the development of a conditioned response (Shimp, 1991). Explication of varying degrees of susceptibility of a brand to impingement from a paired brand bears on these ideas of cognitive stability and strength of attitudes. In this regard, it is contended that high-familiarity brands may defy adoption of brand attitudes and brand personality traits more strongly than low-familiarity brands. In accordance with other studies in the sponsorship field (e.g., Carrillat et al., 2005; Lardinois & Quester, 2001) investigation into the following hypotheses is suggested here:

- H8_{iii-a/b} and H8_{iv-a/b}:** For higher (lower) levels of focal sponsor brand familiarity, the positive relationship between
- i preexposure attitude/associations attributed to a cosponsor,

- ii postexposure attitude/associations attributed to the sponsorship property,

and postexposure attitude/associations attributed to the focal sponsor (as proposed in H1 and H5, respectively) is reduced (enhanced).

RESEARCH DESIGN AND METHODOLOGY

Creation of a Fictitious Sponsorship Alliance

In order to test the proposed research model a fictitious sponsorship alliance had to be composed. Assembling real brands that have not been engaged jointly in an existing sponsorship or other brand alliance assured for the avoidance of any image transfer effects prior to experimental intervention but still allowed to provoke measurable carryover building on preexisting brand images. Given the collaborative approach with a major retailer in Switzerland, this firm's corporate brand was predetermined to be entered into the alliance. Furthermore, selection of a large, triennial sports event in Switzerland as the sponsorship property has followed from a discussion with the retailer's management. Since the study design required for the cosponsor brand to be of uniformly high familiarity (in order to improve the odds of finding transfer effects emanating from that brand in case there are any after all) and for the focal sponsor brand to be of varying familiarity (in order to allow for testing hypotheses of moderation according to H8), the retailer brand was naturally given as the highly familiar cosponsor because it is one of the best known brands among Swiss consumers. The focal sponsor brand was selected based on a pretest ($n = 349$). A manufacturer of photo cameras and equipment proved to fulfill the relevant criteria reasonably well (e.g., large variance in brand familiarity; attitude significantly different from retailer brand).

Experimental Design and Data Collection

Consistent with the research model, a pre-/postmeasurement design was set up with the respondents being exposed to the sponsorship alliance stimulus in between measurements. Two mock news articles, three fabricated billboards, and three photographs promoting the fictitious sponsorship alliance through textual and visual information were used as experimental stimuli. Design and wording was akin to communication actual sponsors deploy, thus maintaining a high degree of realism of the experimental task. Data collection as well as presentation of stimuli was conducted by means of a two-part online survey with a timespan of between five and seven days from preexposure to postexposure inquiry. In

order to obscure the purpose of the experiment, stimuli were offered at the outset of part two with an array of filler questions presented prior to postexposure data collection.

Sampling Procedure

Study participants were recruited from the online access panel of an international market research institute. In order to be in line with the target group of the retailer's main sponsorship activities, the target population for the study was defined as the residents of the German-speaking part of Switzerland aged between 15 and 75. For drawing a representative sample from the target population, the number of initial invitations allocated to distinct geographical sectors was matched to population densities found in these sectors and, additionally, quota on age and gender were applied. After adjustment of the raw sample for cases that had to be dropped for different reasons (e.g., unreasonably short resting time on pages containing stimulus material) a final sample size of $n = 686$ remained for analyses.

Assessment of Measurement Scales

All of the latent variables applied for this research underlie a reflective measurement approach. Four items (7-point semantic differential scales from 1 = bad, to 7 = good; from 1 = unappealing, to 7 = appealing; from 1 = dislikeable, to 7 = likeable; from 1 = unfavorable, to 7 = favorable) have been used to measure brand attitude (Basil & Herr, 2006; Lardinoit & Quester, 2001), while the personality-based perspective on brand image was captured by assessing an array of 13 individual personality traits (Aaker, 1997; Geuens et al., 2009; 7-point Likert scales anchored by: 1 = not at all characteristic, 7 = very characteristic; see Figure 3 for an overview on the traits used). Brand image fit was measured by three items taken from Grohs et al. (2004) and from Speed and Thompson (2000) (brands fit together well; associations with brands are similar; ideas that come to mind when asked about brands are related; 7-point Likert scales anchored by: 1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree). Finally, the brand familiarity scale comprised four items and was inherited from Kent and Allen (1994) supplemented by one item taken from Yoo, Donthu, and Lee (2000) (7-point semantic differential scales from 1 = very unfamiliar, to 7 = very familiar; from 1 = very inexperienced, to 7 = very experienced; from 1 = not very knowledgeable, to 7 = very knowledgeable; from 1 = few associations come to my mind quickly, to 7 = many associations come to my mind quickly). All of the scales used have been tested by means of a comparable study conducted prior to the present work and were adapted if necessary, resulting in the form presented here. Eventually, assessment of the scales used in the work at hand provided satisfactory degrees of reliability and unidimensionality (standardized factor loadings: 0.76–0.97 with $ps < 0.001$;

coefficient alphas: 0.87–0.95; item-to-total correlations: 0.72–0.91; AVEs: 70–85% with one factor extracted for each variable) and discriminant validity was supported by the data for every pair of latent variables.

Method of Data Analysis

A single structural equation (SE) model was used to test the research model with brand image conceptualized as brand attitude, while 13 individual path analysis (PA) models were used to substantiate evidence in support of or against the transfer of brand image conceptualized as a roster of 13 brand personality traits. Fit indexes for the SE model and, respectively, the range of fit index scores across the 13 individual PA models are provided in Figures 2 and 3. Detailed information on model specification and identification, data preparation, model estimation and respecification, as well as the covariance matrix can be obtained from the contact author.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION OF FINDINGS

Results

A manipulation check revealed the experimental requirements to be fully satisfied. Specifically, the focal sponsor brand (photo brand) was inferior compared to the cosponsor brand (retailer brand) in terms of attitude scores ($M_{\text{Photo Brand}} = 5.40$, $SD = 1.06$, $M_{\text{Retailer Brand}} = 6.29$, $SD = 0.89$, $t(685) = -18.14$, $p < 0.001$, $d = 0.91$, 95% CI [0.86, 0.96]). Levels of variance in brand image fit between the focal sponsor and, respectively, the cosponsor and the sponsorship property (event brand) turned out to be reasonably large ($M_{\text{Fit Photo Brand/Retailer Brand}} = 4.07$, $SD^2 = 2.20$; $M_{\text{Fit Photo Brand/Event Brand}} = 3.99$, $SD^2 = 2.65$). Also, an acceptable level of variance in focal sponsor brand familiarity with a uniformly high level of variance in familiarity for the cosponsor brand was achieved ($M_{\text{Familiarity Photo Brand}} = 4.37$, $SD^2 = 1.79$; $M_{\text{Familiarity Retailer Brand}} = 6.23$, $SD^2 = 0.83$).

Examination of the structural model (see Figure 2) and the path models (see Figure 3) shows that the majority of estimated relations concerning brand image transfer within a sponsorship alliance ($H1_{a/b}$ – $H6_{a/b}$) correspond to the predictions. Most notably, regression coefficients and significance levels of the respective SE and PA model paths underscore the central assumption of a positive relationship between the preexposure image of the cosponsor and the postexposure image of the focal sponsor. Specifically, a direct attitudinal effect ($H1_a$) as well as a significant direct conveyance of nine personality traits from the 13 traits roster ($H1_b$) between the retailer brand and the photo brand became apparent. Also, all of the remaining four (nonsignificant) PA paths were in the predicted direction. Thus,

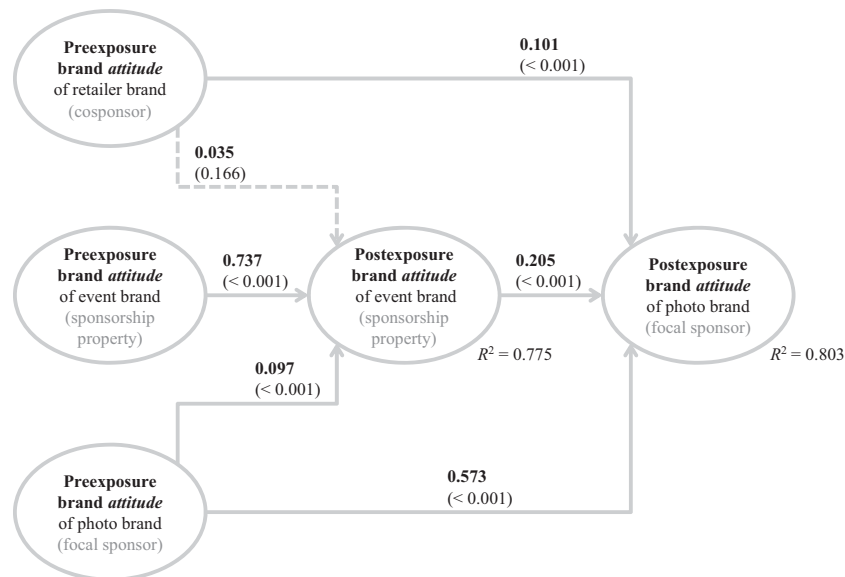


Figure 2. Structural equation (SE) model of brand attitude transfer in a sponsorship alliance. Standardized asymptotically distribution free (ADF) parameter estimates with p values in parentheses.

Model fit indexes: $\chi^2(317) = 950.53$, $\chi^2/\text{df} = 3.00$, GFI = 0.871, AGFI = 0.835, RMSEA = 0.054 with 90% CI [0.050, 0.058], CFI = 0.833

Note: Solid lines represent significant paths at $p < 0.05$. Dashed line represents nonsignificant path.

*** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, ns = nonsignificant.

hypothesis H1_{a/b} is confirmed.³ H2_{a/b} and H4_{a/b} are evaluated jointly since both of them predict image transfer from a sponsor brand (the cosponsor and the focal sponsor, respectively) to the sponsorship property. Concerning H2_{a/b}, attitude transfer was found to be weak and nonsignificant and evidence for brand personality to rub off from the retailer brand to the event brand was found for six traits only (dashed line in Figures 2 and 3, respectively). In contrast, with regard to H4_{a/b}, image transfer from the photo brand to the event brand was fully confirmed both from an attitude-based perspective as well as from a personality-based perspective as corroborated by 7 of 13 personality traits with positive significant paths. In accord with extensive prior research on a central issue of image transfer in sponsorship, the results are also in support of H5_{a/b} assuming a positive relationship between the event's brand image and the image of the photo brand (positive and significant regression coefficient in SE model on attitude transfer, positive and significant path coefficients in PA models for 12 of 13 personality traits). Nonetheless, strength and significance of the relation between the event brand and the photo brand (H5_{a/b}) did not suffice to compensate for the nonsignificance of the image transfer between the retailer brand and the event brand (H2_{a/b}) to, in total, support an indirect effect of the retailer brand

onto the photo brand mediated by the property ($b2_a \times b5_a = 0.007$, $p = 0.174$;⁴ only the four personality traits of ordinary, simple, romantic, and sentimental with significant mediated relationships $b2_b \times b5_b$). Assessment of the results relating to attitude stability and stability of brand knowledge structures pertaining to the focal sponsor and the sponsorship property unambiguously confirm the corresponding hypotheses (H3_{a/b} and H6_{a/b}).

Multigroup invariance testing procedures on SE and PA models were conducted in order to assess the proposed moderation effects. The procedure involves restricting moderated paths equal across respondent groups that result from a split of the sample at the median of the moderating variable. Testing for significance of the difference in χ^2 between a model with equality restrictions imposed and a simultaneously estimated unconstrained (configural) model allows for assessment of nonvariance/invariance of median-split groups on the path estimate in question. Since smaller values of χ^2 represent better fit, a larger χ^2 of the restricted model compared to the configural model gives rise to assuming a moderation effect. Thus, positive $\Delta\chi^2$ ($\chi^2_{\text{Restricted Model}} - \chi^2_{\text{Configural Model}}$) is indicative for moderation if the corresponding p -value suggests significance of that difference at $p < 0.05$ and if, simultaneously, testing for invariance of the restricted and the configural model's measurement structures suggest these to be equal at $p > 0.05$ (Kline, 2010).

³ With regard to testing the personality-based parts of the hypotheses (i.e., subscript "b"), these were rejected in case the stated relationship/interaction failed to be substantiated at a level of significance of $p < 0.05$ for the majority of personality traits—that is, if the relationship/interaction is rejected in seven or more of the 13 personality traits. Otherwise the hypothesis is regarded as confirmed.

⁴ The standard error required for calculating critical ratio and p -value was estimated using an approach suggested by Sobel (1986).

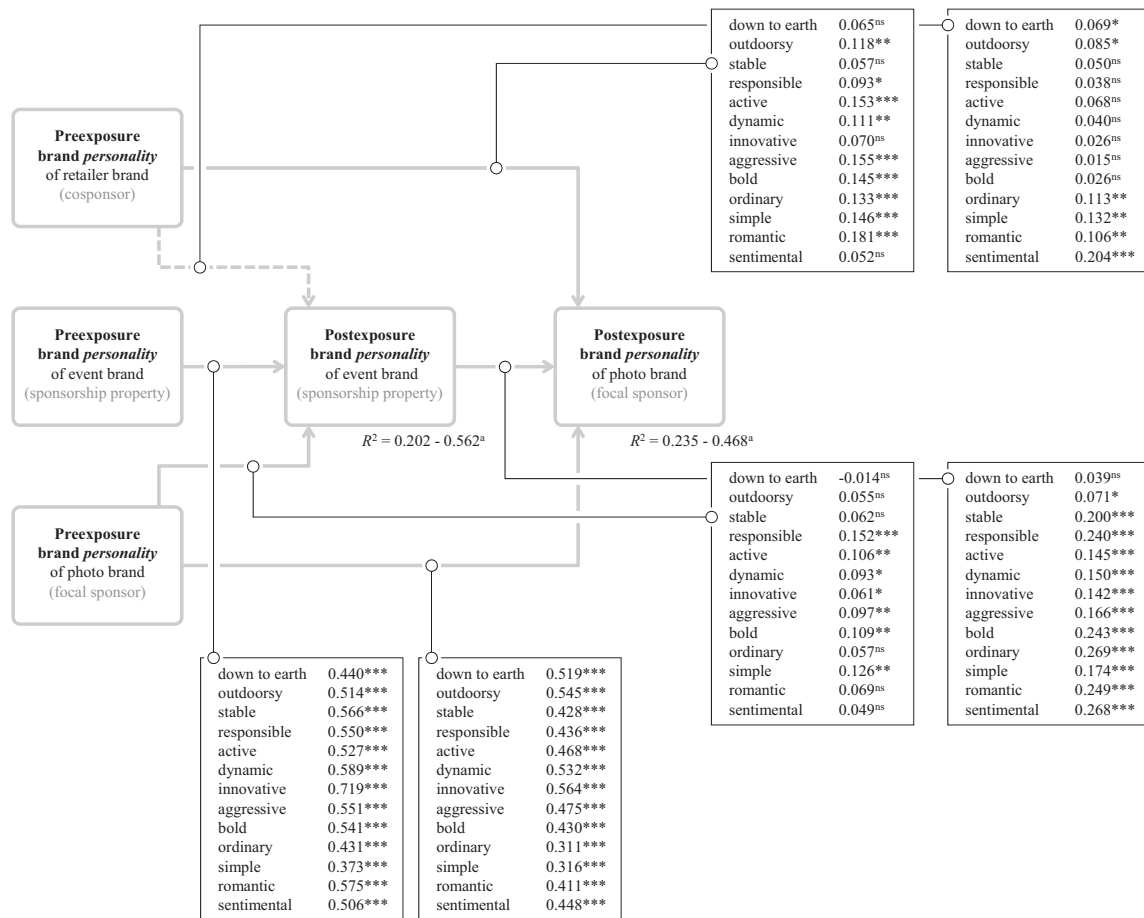


Figure 3. Thirteen individual path analysis (PA) models of brand personality transfer in a sponsorship alliance. Standardized asymptotically distribution free (ADF) parameter estimates.

Range of model fit indexes across the 13 PA models: $\chi^2(1) = 0.00-7.84$, $\chi^2/df = 0.00-27.84$, GFI = 0.982-1.000, AGFI = 0.730-1.000, RMSEA = 0.000 with 90% CI [0.000, 0.000]-0.206 with 90% CI [0.144, 0.275], CFI = 0.951-1.000.

^aRange of R^2 values across the 13 PA models.

Note: Solid lines represent composite brand personality transfer pathways with more than half of the constituent paths representing the 13 personality attributes significant at $p < 0.05$. Dashed line represents nonsignificant pathways following the same logic.

*** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, ns = nonsignificant.

Corresponding to the suppositions all of the relationships proposed to represent attitude transfer between any two brands are moderated by brand image fit between these brands. In support of H7_{i-a} to H7_{iv-a} it was found that attitude transfer on moderated pathways is elevated in the respondent-group perceiving high fit between two brands, while attitude transfer is annihilated in the group sensing a low level of fit (see Table 1). With regard to enhancement/inhibition of the carryover of single brand associations, the results are somewhat ambivalent. While the majority of moderation effects were found to be in the direction implied by hypotheses H7_{i-b} through H7_{iv-b}, only the transfer of personality traits from the property brand to the focal sponsor brand did in fact receive significant support for being moderated by perceived property/focal sponsor brand fit (H7_{iv-b}, result tables of χ^2 difference tests on H7_{i-b} through H7_{iv-b} can be obtained from the contact

author). This confirms H7_{iv-b} but does not lend full support to hypotheses H7_{i-b} through H7_{iii-b}.

Moderation effects expected to be induced by the level of familiarity with the focal sponsor (higher vs. lower) and suggested to result in differential strength of the focal sponsor brand to imbue a paired brand (enhanced vs. reduced) are found to be mildly opposed to the direction suggested by the corresponding hypotheses (H8_{i-a/b} and H8_{ii-a/b}). Estimation results reveal the relationship between preexposure and postexposure attitude toward the photo brand to be of almost equal strength across the two familiarity groups with a marginal prevalence in the low familiarity group (H8_{i-a}, see Table 2). Correspondingly, the regression coefficient on the transfer from focal sponsor brand to property brand as found for the low familiarity group slightly exceeds the coefficient in the high-familiarity group in terms of strength (H8_{ii-a}). Outcomes with

Table 1. χ^2 Difference Tests Concerning Moderating Effect of Brand Image Fit on Attitude Transfer.

Moderated path	High Image Fit Between Brands Spanning the Moderated Path		Low Image Fit Between Brands Spanning the Moderated Path		Model Comparison			Mdr*
	<i>b</i>	<i>p</i> -Value	<i>b</i>	<i>p</i> -Value	$\Delta\chi^2$	Δdf	<i>p</i> -Value	
Pre_attd_co ↳ Post_attd_foc (H7 _{i-a})	0.192	0.001	0.025	0.576	35.594	20	0.017	☑
Pre_attd_co ↳ Post_attd_prop (H7 _{ii-a})	0.151	0.004	−0.059	0.091	49.748	25	0.002	☑
Pre_attd_foc ↳ Post_attd_prop (H7 _{iii-a})	0.149	0.005	0.006	0.857	31.798	20	0.045	☑
Post_attd_prop ↳ Post_attd_foc (H7 _{iv-a})	0.345	<0.001	0.020	0.726	50.959	20	<0.001	☑

*Moderation effect (Mdr) supported with $b_{\text{High Image Fit}} > b_{\text{Low Image Fit}}$ and $\Delta\chi^2$ significant at level $p < 0.05$: ☑; moderation effect not supported with $b_{\text{High Image Fit}} > b_{\text{Low Image Fit}}$ and $\Delta\chi^2$ nonsignificant at level $p > 0.05$, or with $b_{\text{High Image Fit}} < b_{\text{Low Image Fit}}$: ☒.

Pre_attd_co = preexposure attitude toward cosponsor; Post_attd_foc = postexposure attitude toward focal sponsor; Post_attd_prop = postexposure attitude toward sponsorship property; Pre_attd_foc = preexposure attitude toward cosponsor.

Note 1: Separation into High Image Fit group versus Low Image Fit group was conducted according to median split of sample.

Note 2: Larger *b* values are in boldface.

Table 2. χ^2 Difference Tests Concerning Moderating Effect of Focal Sponsor Brand Familiarity on Attitude Transfer.

Moderated path:	High Familiarity of Focal Sponsor		Low Familiarity of Focal Sponsor		Model Comparison			Mdr
	<i>b</i>	<i>p</i> -Value	<i>b</i>	<i>p</i> -Value	$\Delta\chi^2$	Δdf	<i>p</i> -Value	
Pre_attd_foc ↳ Post_attd_foc (H8 _{i-a})	0.599	<0.001	0.600	<0.001	36.499	27	0.105	☒ ^a
Pre_attd_foc ↳ Post_attd_prop (H8 _{ii-a})	0.050	0.246	0.068	0.089	36.119	27	0.113	☒ ^a
Pre_attd_co ↳ Post_attd_foc (H8 _{iii-a})	0.135	0.009	0.058	0.197	37.038	27	0.094	☒ ^b
Post_attd_prop ↳ Post_attd_foc (H8 _{iv-a})	0.214	<0.001	0.123	0.051	38.395	27	0.072	☒ ^b

^aH8_{i-a}, H8_{ii-a} = moderation effect (Mdr) supported with $b_{\text{High Familiarity}} > b_{\text{Low Familiarity}}$ and $\Delta\chi^2$ significant at level $p < 0.05$: ☑; moderation effect not supported with $b_{\text{High Familiarity}} > b_{\text{Low Familiarity}}$ and $\Delta\chi^2$ nonsignificant, or with $b_{\text{High Familiarity}} < b_{\text{Low Familiarity}}$: ☒.

^bH8_{iii-a}, H8_{iv-a} = moderation effect supported with $b_{\text{High Familiarity}} < b_{\text{Low Familiarity}}$ and $\Delta\chi^2$ significant at level $p < 0.05$: ☑; moderation effect not supported with $b_{\text{High Familiarity}} < b_{\text{Low Familiarity}}$ and $\Delta\chi^2$ nonsignificant, or with $b_{\text{High Familiarity}} > b_{\text{Low Familiarity}}$: ☒.

Pre_attd_foc = preexposure attitude toward focal sponsor; Post_attd_foc = postexposure attitude toward focal sponsor; Post_attd_prop = postexposure attitude toward sponsorship property; Pre_attd_co = Preexposure attitude toward cosponsor.

Note 1: Separation into High Familiarity group versus Low Familiarity group was conducted according to median split of sample.

Note 2: Larger *b* values are in boldface.

regard to the conveyance of personality profiles, on the other hand, are in the expected direction and show that the majority of attributes is subject to a stronger carryover in the high-familiarity group compared to the low familiarity group (H8_{i-b} and H8_{ii-b}, result tables of χ^2 difference tests on H8_{i-b} through H8_{iv-b} can be obtained from the contact author). Nevertheless, none of the multigroup invariance tests on these moderation effects—neither the attitude related nor the personality

related—show acceptable levels of significance which ultimately leads to rejecting hypotheses H8_{i-a/b} and H8_{ii-a/b}.

Interestingly, moderation effects expected to be induced by the level of familiarity with the focal sponsor (higher vs. lower) and proposed to yield varying degrees of susceptibility of that brand to impingement from an paired brand (lower vs. higher) are severely at odds with what has been anticipated (H8_{iii-a/b} and H8_{iv-a/b}).

In effect, the photo brand seems to be more susceptible to, respectively, attitudinal impact and rub offs of associations from the retailer as well as from the event brand in case of high compared to low familiarity. In light of these unexpected results, hypotheses H8_{iii-a/b} and H8_{iv-a/b} are rejected, though it will be instructive to further elaborate on this outcome in the subsequent discussion.

Discussion of Findings

Direct Rub-Off from Cosponsor to Focal Sponsor.

This study contributes to sponsorship literature in that it provides evidence in support of the idea that a sponsor might not only benefit from exploitation of a sponsorship property's image (H5_{a/b}), but that it also stands to gain from brand attitudes and brand associations innately tied to a cosponsor (H1_{a/b}). In effect, two brands concurrently sponsoring the same event may add an extra effect to the image gain they seek to garner from the property by cross-fertilizing with regard to their own images. While research on brand alliance or cobranding has well established popularity for the notion that two brands might exert a reciprocative effect concerning their images when paired through a joint marketing effort (see, e.g., Levin, 2002; Rao et al., 1999; Walchli, 2007), the study presented here underscores the relevance of a mutual impact in the context of a sponsorship alliance. In fact, this investigation is the first to comprehensively demonstrate brand image transfer among the brands constituting a sponsorship alliance in its most parsimonious form. Extending on the attitude-based perspective, the personality-based view provides support for the notion that transfer of ideas and thoughts is also manifested when these brands are processed in a piecemeal (personality traits) rather than a category-based (attitudes) fashion (Fiske & Pavelchak, 1986). Noteworthy is the affirmation of a personality profile to rub off—on a direct pathway and in large part—from a cosponsor to the focal sponsor (H1_b). This insight is entirely new to research in sponsorship.

Mediated Route of Radiation. With regard to the mediated route from the cosponsor to the focal sponsor via the sponsored event (H2_{a/b} + H5_{a/b}), the results are a bit vague. Affirming extensive prior research on a central issue of image transfer in sponsorship, the findings are, as outlined above, in support of H5_{a/b} that posits a positive relationship between the brand image of the event and the photo brand's image. However, attitudes or associations were not found to transfer from the retailer brand to the event brand (H2_{a/b}) and analysis of the indirect effect of the retailer brand onto the photo brand mediated by the event brand did, consequently, not lend credence to that oblique relationship. Yet, as the photo brand (in contrast to the retailer brand) did exert a significant image effect on the event (support for H4_{a/b} in contrast to H2_{a/b}), there is reason to believe

that a sponsor brand's image might still be transferred to a sponsored event under certain conditions. For one thing, the novelty of a sponsor/event pairing may play a role in eliciting a measurable transfer effect. Due to the retailer's endorsement of some popular athletes who prominently compete in the event series examined here, retailer/event convergence of brand images might have taken place prior to the experimental manipulation, depriving the analysis of a seizable effect on the retailer-to-event route (H2_{a/b}). On the contrary, the photo/event pairing was novel to the respondents as no prior relationship whatsoever did exist and, thus, transfer between these brands might have taken place not before the experimental intervention (H4_{a/b}). For another thing, rub-off of the retailer brand image onto the event brand has been shown to be enhanced in case these brands were perceived as matching well (significant support for H7_{ii-a}, and H7_{ii-b} in expected direction, albeit not significant). Looking at the indirect relationship of interest between the retailer brand and the photo brand in the group of respondents perceiving these two brands to be a good match reveals that enhancement to result in an admittedly small yet significant indirect pathway for the transfer of attitude (H2_a + H5_a, $b2_a \times b5_a = 0.027$, $p = 0.047$). Remember that in the main-effect model, that is, in the nonmoderated model, the indirect pathway was not found to be significant (H2_a + H5_a; $b2_a \times b5_a = 0.007$, $p = 0.174$). However, alongside the fortification of the mediated pathway in case of high image fit for the retailer/event pairing, the direct pathway from retailer brand to the photo brand is losing strength compared to what the main effect predicted (dropping from $b1_a = 0.101$, $p < 0.001$ to $b1_a = 0.034$, $p = 0.484$). That is, an increase in attitude transfer strength for the indirect route is compensated for by a decreased strength on the direct route. A corresponding pattern of compensation is evident for the transfer of brand personality traits. That is, eight of the nine traits (the trait of bold is the exception) that have been identified to rub off from the retailer brand to the photo brand in the main effects PA models lose strength on their respective $b1_b$ weights, while simultaneously gaining strength on their respective $b2_b$ weights (corresponding to H7_{ii-b} being in the expected direction) and $b5_b$ weights in the case of high retailer/event fit. Note, however, that the combined $b2_b \times b5_b$ path does reach significance only for those traits that have already been found to significantly transfer on the mediated route in the main effects models (i.e., ordinary, simple, romantic, sentimental; result tables on mediation effects in the personality-based PA models can be obtained from the contact author). Altogether, albeit the main effects model being devoid of support for an indirect effect, the above-noted deliberations give rise to the assumption that a mediated route of radiation from the retailer brand onto the photo brand might come into effect if (1) the retailer/event relationship is not yet strongly established and/or if (2) these brands exert a high level of fit.

Attitudinal Stability and Inert Personality Profiles. Before addressing the moderation effects it seems worth noting that, as anticipated, both the photo brand and the event brand did exert attitudinal stability ($H3_a$ and $H6_a$) as well as a high level of inertness concerning any modification of their personality profiles ($H3_b$ and $H6_b$). In accordance with this, other authors also found brand images to be slow to change through sponsorship due to effects of persistency originating in these brands' past images (e.g., Lafferty, Goldsmith, & Hult, 2004; McDaniel, 1999). Summarizing this line of empirical evidence from sponsorship literature, Grohs et al. (2004) acknowledge that "the most influential predictor of postevent sponsor image is, as expected, preevent sponsor image" (p. 131).

Brand Image Fit Facilitates Attitude Transfer.

Apparently, between-sponsor transfer of attitude is enhanced by increased levels of focal sponsor/cosponsor fit ($H7_{i-a}$ accepted), whereas only partial support for a moderation effect is found with regard to the carry-over of the brand personality profile ($H7_{i-b}$ rejected, yet with a majority of personality traits exerting path coefficients in the expected direction). While the finding in regard to an augmentation of attitude transfer through increased congruence was anticipated, the absence of a significant moderation effect on personality traits was unexpected, yet corresponds to the outcome of Carrillat et al.'s (2010) study on brand image transfer in concurrent sponsorships. These authors' results suggest that transfer of single personality dimensions takes place when two sponsor brands with similar concepts (i.e., fitting sponsors) are paired together, while no transfer (but even contrasting effects) are observed when brand concepts are dissimilar (i.e., nonfitting sponsors). However, it follows from their study that the moderating effect of brand concept similarity (i.e., brand fit) was muted in the case of two low familiarity brands being paired. Likewise, since only one of the sponsor brands utilized in the study at hand can unambiguously be considered a high-familiarity brand (i.e., the retailer brand) while the other sponsor brand can, at best, be regarded as a brand of mediocre familiarity (i.e., the photo brand), a moderation effect of between-sponsor brand image fit may have been impeded.

Confirmation of hypotheses $H7_{ii-a}$ and $H7_{iii-a}$ lends credence to the idea of a reverse-sponsorship effect (Becker-Olsen & Hill, 2006; Burmann et al., 2013; Ruth & Simonin, 2006). Namely, it supports the presumption of a sponsoring brand having the capacity to benefit (or debilitate) a property's brand through image transfer and, in this way, counteracting the traditional course of property-to-sponsor transfer. Thus, for the group of respondents being comfortable with, respectively, the retailer brand/event brand matchup and the photo brand/event brand matchup, these results are in line with Ruth and Simonin's (2003) finding that attitudes toward sponsor brands account for a significant portion of variance in consumers' development of attitudes toward the sponsored event. Even though both

$H7_{ii-b}$ and $H7_{iii-b}$ were rejected, the results are in partial support for the assertion that brand personality may be transferred from a sponsor to a sponsorship property in case these brands' images are perceived as congruent. Path coefficients being in the expected direction, yet lacking significance in most cases, support this conclusion for a majority of personality traits. This is in line with what Henseler et al. (2009) found.

Moderation of image transfer from the sponsored property to a sponsor brand is the one relationship out of the entire framework put to test in the study at hand that has enjoyed the lion's share of scholar attention in the past. The results obtained here confirm propositions made in sponsorship literature (see, e.g., Grohs & Reisinger, 2005; Gwinner, 1997; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999) in that attitude transfer from the event brand to the photo brand was found to be enhanced by the perception of fit between these brands ($H7_{iv-a}$). Extending current knowledge, the present study also demonstrates that brand image fit interacts with brand image transfer on the piecemeal level of single personality traits ($H7_{iv-b}$).

Familiar Sponsor Brands May Stand to Gain More.

Inferring from principles of cognitive stability, it has been anticipated that transfer onto the focal sponsor will be muted when this brand is perceived as being highly familiar, whereas conveyance will be relatively strong in case this brand lacks an extensive and stable network of prior associations ($H8_{iii-a/b}$ and $H8_{iv-a/b}$). However, image transfer was found to be intensified in the high-familiarity group, while transfer was attenuated in the low-familiarity group—a finding contrary to the original conjecture. Building on these results, it must be assumed that sponsor brands blessed with a vivid and rich consumer imagination stand to gain more from their cosponsors than "anemic" brands. Categorization theory may provide an explanation for this unanticipated outcome. It has been proposed that people tend to categorize similar objects together, while dissimilar objects are assigned to different mental categories (Medin, Goldstone, & Gentner, 1993; Rosch & Mervis, 1975). According to Tversky's (1977) similarity model, common and distinctive features of two objects are weighted by the saliency of these features to obtain a measure of similarity. In effect, objects with common salient features are categorized together, whereas objects with distinctive salient features are allocated to different categories. Furthermore, through an assimilation effect, objects assigned to the same category tend to be perceived as even more similar (Krueger & Clement, 1994). On these grounds, heightened familiarity conceived as saliency of brand attributes might be interpreted as a condition sine qua non for brand image fit—a concept that may be interpreted as coextensive with Tversky's feature commonality—to exert a moderating influence on the assimilation of two brands' images. In other words, brand familiarity might not be a moderating variable on its own account but may rather be a precondition for moderating effects of brand image

Table 3. *t* Tests on the Comparison of Mean Pre-Exposure Brand Familiarity Scores in High Versus Low Brand Image Fit Groups.

Preexposure brand familiarity	Brand Image Fit Between Focal Sponsor and Cosponsor				Brand Image Fit Between Focal Sponsor and Sponsorship Property			
	<i>M</i> _{High Fit}	<i>M</i> _{Low Fit}	df	<i>p</i> -Value	<i>M</i> _{High Fit}	<i>M</i> _{Low Fit}	df	<i>p</i> -Value
Focal sponsor	4.64	4.15	677	<0.001				
Cosponsor	6.33	6.17	677	<0.001				
Focal sponsor					4.63	4.17	677	<0.001
Sponsorship property					3.72	3.28	677	<0.001

Note 1: Separation into High Fit groups versus Low Fit groups was conducted according to median split of sample.

Note 2: Larger means are in boldface.

fit to materialize in the first place. The data correspond to this line of reasoning. For the brand pairs of which the focal sponsor is a part, familiarity levels of both brands are significantly higher in the high-brand image fit groups compared to the low-fit groups (see Table 3). Put another way, the data does not obviate the argumentation that increased strength of image transfer in the high-fit groups does unfold through a categorization process that also relies on increased levels of brand familiarity in these groups. On the other hand, image transfer might be inhibited in the low-fit groups because categorization and, hence, assimilation does not unfold in the case where two objects with distinctive, unfamiliar features are paired.

Conclusions and Implications for Practitioners

Motivated by the obvious contrast between sponsorship reality, where multiple sponsors concurrently being engaged with a single property is the norm, and sponsorship research, where attention has mainly been given to investigation of solo sponsorship, this study aimed at answering the question of whether or not the brand image inherently tied to one sponsor may be transferred to a paired sponsor. In fact, empirical substantiation of direct image transference between two sponsor brands allows for providing straightforward and valuable advice concerning sponsorship policy formulation and execution. Complementing such forthright advice, elaboration of the more intricate suggestions originating from the insight of perceived image fit to evidently enhance between-sponsors image transfer seems worthwhile too. The same is true for the finding of a minimum level of brand familiarity being required for a sponsor brand's image to become augmented by cooccurring with another sponsor. Subsequently, some practical implications of these key insights will be outlined.

Because brand image rub-offs must be expected to flow not only from the sponsored property, but also from the cosponsors, brand managers may gain from whom they share a perimeter billboard or any other ad space in sponsorship with; but they must also be aware of detrimental effects. Being paired with a cosponsor might fortify or dilute a sponsor brand's image depend-

ing on the expediency of the image conveyed by that concomitant entity. Accordingly, with due regard to the advice of eschewing improper or unfavorable cosponsors, it seems consequential to call on brand managers to capitalize on the brand image potential that resides within the other sponsors instead of limiting the looked-for benefits to what the sponsorship property brings to the table. In fact, rather than maintaining a "wait and see" mindset toward image transfer, brand managers investing their respective brands into a common sponsorship settlement should collectively and preemptively define as to which particular associations each brand is destined to benefit from the allied brands. Going a step further, even the concrete measures by which the selected personality traits are to be transferred may be predetermined. Such type of association-centered approach to between-sponsors image transfer specifically measures up to a practitioner's aim of positioning a brand in the marketplace by building a distinct personality profile rather than just presiding over an equivocal attitude. In this regard, comparable to what was shown for brand alliances (Park et al., 1996), it can be conjectured that the mutual gain of the brands allying through sponsorship is more positive if these brands are complementary rather than similar. The gain may be even more accentuated in case the alliance has not yet been established. Here, as opposed to a situation in which the composition of sponsor brands is predefined through an alliance that is already in place, two or more prospective sponsor brands may join forces and define shared goals even before linking up to a common sponsorship property. For example, a maker of high-end automobiles such as BMW and a manufacturer of luxury watches such as Longines could decide to jointly invite their most valuable customers to a high-brow arts event. The two brands might agree on such an activity based on the objective of mutually gaining from the image of the respective other. That is, BMW may reap some of the elegance perception attributed to Longines and Longines could prosper on its characteristic of being technically advanced by inheritance from BMW. This way, the alliance partners build a planned rather than fortuitous composition of—complementary yet not similar—brands. After arranging the brand alliance, the management may then attempt to find a suitable property such as Art Basel. Additionally, for

mitigating brand image risks arising from yet another cosponsor that might apply for admission to an ongoing sponsorship collaboration, an existing (top tier) sponsor (as BMW or Longines are) should stipulate to be entitled to veto such an assignment to the alliance in case the new sponsor is perceived to be of harm to the own image.

As transfer effects have been found to actually be more accentuated in case consumers feel that the allied sponsors' images fit well, the above recommendations are amended by the advice to evaluate brand matchup before entering into collaboration. Such an assessment must be conducted in the target markets of each brand and should capture the extent of overlap of symbolic and intangible associations rather than functional attributes. Cornwell et al. (2005) note that articulating a reason for the pairing of two or more brands through sponsorship may enforce perceived fit between these brands and, thus, supports sponsorship outcome. With regard to the BMW and Longines example introduced above, this means that both brands must test for congruence with the other brand as perceived by their respective clientele of choice. If it turns out that the BMW buyers and/or the Longines customers do not see a natural link or overlap between these brands, it is advisable to not proceed with the sponsorship alliance endeavor and instead look for alternative partners. Assuring explicit articulation of a link that might be seen by the managers of both brands but, as yet, not by the customers may be a remedy for naturally incongruous allies.

The (unexpected) finding related to the enhanced transfer to the focal sponsor from both the cosponsor and the sponsorship property in case the target brand is well known and cognitively multifaceted brings about the novel insight that some perceptual kernel may be required in order for a sponsor to become associatively enriched by allied brands. Outlining the effect of prior experience with a sponsor brand, Cornwell et al. (2005) note that "familiarity . . . positively impacts the perceived relations between new stimuli and existing associations". (p. 32). As such, a sponsor brand largely unknown in western European or North American key markets of alpine skiing and devoid of at least a rudimentary stem of associations, such as Stobag (a Swiss manufacturer of sun and weather protection systems), may remain largely untouched by fellow sponsor brands' images and even by the property brand when sponsoring the FIS Alpine Ski World Cup. At the same time, more prominent sponsors such as Audi are likely to benefit from their engagement by inheriting associations innately tied to the cosponsors and the event. The recommendation that emerges from this insight to brand managers is to make sure of a sufficient degree of brand familiarity in the target market of the intended sponsorship property. Given naturally low levels of brand familiarity in "white spot" territories, sponsorship may not be the instrument of choice for entering a new market. Thus, prior to quest for brand image enhancement by means of a sponsorship alliance, it is

advisable to anchor some key brand attributes in the mind of consumers through classical advertising.

FURTHER RESEARCH

The results of the present study are indicative of a majority of 9 of 13 brand personality traits to transfer from one sponsor brand to the other. However, the answer to the question of why these nine attributes were found to be subject to a carryover, while the remaining four were seemingly immune to transference, remained open. A possible explanation taps into the saliency of personality traits and contends that more characteristic traits or traits that stand out prominently from the profile of the radiating sponsor are transferred more easily. However, attribute saliency for the brand from which the image transfer emanates embraces but one side of a transfer relationship; the saliency or cognitive prominence of that attribute as pertinent to the receiving brand might play a role too. Specifically, if a brand attribute protrudes from the rest of the personality traits and if this attribute is perceived to be uniquely characteristic for the receiving brand, it might be inert to persuasive attempts. Creation of a measure of "differential saliency" between two sponsor brands for each personality trait, and testing for a potential moderating effect of this measure on transfer, seems a subject matter worth probing into.

The experimental design of the study implicates that respondents replied to questions and looked at or read the fictitious sponsorship alliance stimuli in an environment that most likely lacks resemblance to the surroundings of a real sponsorship property (e.g., at home or in an office space). It has not been possible for the respondents to immerse themselves into the ambiance of the event. Also, in an authentic sponsorship situation consumers are usually exposed to multiple stimuli over an extended period of time through different media. Design of future research attempts might therefore rely on a real-life sponsorship setting in order to enhance the external validity of the current study.

Utilization of a personality scale with traits idiosyncratically describing the sponsor brands (instead of applying a nonspecific roster of 13 associations) might further enhance verisimilitude and realism.

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